

MI Healthy Climate Challenge #4: Go Big, Go Clean

Application Evaluation Criteria

The criteria below describe how applications to Challenge #4: Go Big, Go Clean will be evaluated. Each section corresponds to a weighted evaluation criterion. Reviewers will assess each application against the criteria listed and assign a score within the indicated point range. Total scores inform award recommendations, alongside the additional considerations noted at the end of this document.

Section 1: Emissions Impact Potential and Depth of Decarbonization

Weight: 30% | 0–30 points

What reviewers will look for:

- Meaningful potential to reduce greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions, including a clearly presented facility baseline drawn from the U.S. Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) Facility Level Information on Greenhouse Gases Tool (FLIGHT)/Greenhouse Gas Reporting Program (GHGRP) data (for facilities that report at that threshold) or an activity-data-based estimate using facility energy and fuel consumption data and standard emissions factors.
- Analysis of interventions with potential for deeper decarbonization over time, including pathways with the potential to reduce facility emissions by at least 50%.
- Clear assessment of estimated GHG impacts for each intervention evaluated, including identification of the data sources, emissions factors, and tools (e.g., AVOIDed Emissions and geneRation Tool (AVERT) for electricity-affecting interventions; EPA stationary combustion factors for fuel-switching and efficiency measures) used or planned for bounding estimates.
- Prioritization of high-impact options with strong emissions-reduction potential relative to the facility baseline, with near-term and longer-term opportunities distinguished.
- Scenario-based analysis of how emissions impacts could change under different policy, market, infrastructure, or technology conditions, with explicit identification of the conditions that would make deeper reductions viable.

Insufficient: 0–10 points

Minimal or unclear GHG analysis; decarbonization pathways are absent, too vague to evaluate, or lack any estimate of emissions reduction magnitude;

Adequate: 11–22 points

Facility baseline is identified and near-term interventions are described with general emissions estimates; some scenario framing is present but

Strong: 23–30 points

Rigorous, quantified GHG analysis across near- and long-term pathways grounded in a clearly defined facility baseline; estimation approach, data

baseline is undefined or estimation approach is not described	conditions and assumptions are not clearly linked to specific outcomes; estimation approach and data sources are mentioned but incompletely described	sources, and tools are explicitly identified; robust scenario-based evaluation shows how emissions impacts shift under different conditions; near- and long-term opportunities are clearly distinguished, with at least one pathway demonstrating potential for 50% or greater emissions reduction
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Section 2: Facility Commitment and Likelihood of Use

Weight: 20% | 0–20 points

What reviewers will look for:

- Active, named Michigan industrial facility (or facilities) participating meaningfully in the study, not only providing a one-time letter of support.
- Confirmed access to the facility data, operations, and staff needed to conduct the study, without requiring disclosure of proprietary or sensitive business information to the State.
- Named involvement of at least one industrial facility decision-maker capable of acting on study results.
- Evidence of credible likelihood that study findings will inform real facility-level investment or planning decisions.
- Evidence of leveraged or matched funds strengthens this criterion (not required, but considered).

Insufficient: 0–7 points Facility partner unnamed, uncommitted, or unlikely to meaningfully use or act on study results	Adequate: 8–15 points Named facility with stated commitment and general access to data and staff, with plausible path to use	Strong: 16–20 points Strong, documented facility partnership with decision-maker involvement and high credibility that results will drive near-term action
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Section 3: Community Benefits and Co-Benefits

Weight: 15% | 0–15 points

What reviewers will look for:

- Consideration of workforce impacts: job quality, training needs, and transition effects associated with decarbonization pathways.
- Assessment of local community and public health implications (e.g., air quality improvements, reduced environmental burdens in neighboring communities).
- Identification of local economic co-benefits such as supply chain opportunities, local procurement, or workforce development.
- Plan for meaningful engagement of community or environmental justice organizations, particularly for facilities located in or near disadvantaged communities, including proposed partnerships that can support engagement and community outreach (not required, but considered) during the study analysis.
- Plans for community benefit analyses or subawards (up to 5% of award) that are clearly tied to the facility.

Insufficient: 0–5 points

Minimal or no consideration of workforce, community, or public health impacts associated with decarbonization pathways

Adequate: 6–11 points

Some consideration of co-benefits with general connection to community or workforce context and basic analysis planned

Strong: 12–15 points

Strong integration of community and workforce impacts into study design, with clear, actionable analysis and meaningful community engagement

Section 4: Technology and Innovation Value

Weight: 15% | 0–15 points

What reviewers will look for:

Evaluation of promising, emerging, or underutilized industrial decarbonization technologies relevant to the facility or sector.

Inclusion of at least one forward-looking or conditional intervention alongside near-term options. Note that carbon capture and storage on its own is not an eligible intervention for evaluation under this program.

Commitment to explore and the evaluation of innovative approaches to process optimization, electrification, circularity, supply-chain decarbonization, and/or enabling infrastructure.

Clear articulation of what barriers (e.g., cost, policy, infrastructure, technology) must be overcome to make less mature technologies viable.

Assessment of how technology progress, policy signals, or market changes could shift feasibility and economics over time.

Insufficient: 0–5 points

Conventional or narrow intervention set; limited innovation value; no meaningful forward-looking analysis

Adequate: 6–11 points

Includes some innovative or emerging technologies with basic scenario framing for future feasibility

Strong: 12–15 points

Strong innovation focus with rigorous analysis of emerging technologies, enabling conditions, and forward-looking decarbonization pathways with practical implementation framing

Section 5: Replicability and Value to Michigan

Weight: 10% | 0–10 points

What reviewers will look for:

- Transferable insights useful to other Michigan facilities or sectors beyond those directly studied at project conclusion.
- Potential to inform state industrial decarbonization strategy, policy design, or future program development, as evidenced by the transferability of findings, the clarity of barrier and enabling-condition analysis, and the applicant's participation in EGLE-hosted knowledge-sharing activities.
- Multi-facility projects or sector-wide applicability that amplify the value of the study.
- Public-facing summary and knowledge-sharing commitments designed to reach other Michigan facilities and stakeholders.
- Willingness to participate in EGLE-hosted peer-learning, webinar, conference panel, or other knowledge-sharing activities.

Insufficient: 0–3 points

Findings are highly facility-specific with limited broader relevance or knowledge-sharing planned

Adequate: 4–7 points

Some transferable insights with general applicability to other facilities or sectors and a basic sharing plan

Strong: 8–10 points

Highly replicable study design with clear sector-wide or statewide learning value and a strong, concrete knowledge-sharing plan

Section 6: Team Competence and Project Approach

Weight: 10% | 0–10 points

What reviewers will look for:

- Qualifications and relevant experience of the project team across engineering, energy/emissions analysis, financial modeling, and community engagement and benefits analysis where such activities are proposed.
- Clearly defined roles and responsibilities across the lead applicant, facility partner, and technical team.
- Realistic, well-structured project timeline and budget with clear justification for all major cost categories.
- Demonstrated ability to manage similarly complex analytical or feasibility-study projects.
- Clear work plan describing how the required deliverable package (final report, slide deck, and public-facing summary) will be produced.

Insufficient: 0–3 points

Team lacks relevant expertise; project approach, timeline, or budget is unclear or incomplete

Adequate: 4–7 points

Competent team with adequate expertise and a reasonable, mostly complete project plan

Strong: 8–10 points

Highly qualified team with deep technical expertise, clearly defined roles, and a well-developed, feasible work plan with strong budget justification

Additional Considerations

In addition to numeric scores, final funding decisions may consider:

- Sector diversity — does totality of selected projects collectively cover a range of Michigan industrial sectors, processes, and emissions profiles?
- Multi-facility applicability — are individual study findings likely to benefit a broad set of similar Michigan facilities beyond those directly studied?
- Readiness to act on near-term recommendations — does the facility have the capacity and demonstrated intent to move forward with feasible interventions?
- Collective coverage of intervention types — do funded studies together address a variety of decarbonization approaches, from energy efficiency to advanced electrification and emerging technologies?
- Alignment with other EGLE and state programs.

Questions? Contact NeuenfeldtH@Michigan.gov or visit michigan.gov/MHCChallenge for the full Program Guide and application materials.